CHARACTER BOOKLET · NO. 22

Merritt *Oxley*

TOWN CLERK CARRYING VESPER'S PAPERS

"You carry the papers. You read the papers. You can't say a word about the papers."



FOR MERRITT OXLEY'S EYES ONLY · DO NOT SHARE THIS BOOKLET

OPTIONAL CHARACTER

JOINS AT 13+ PLAYERS

COSTUME FROM YOUR CLOSET

A blazer or neat cardigan, a folder of papers and a fountain pen (any pen) clipped to your pocket.

Mask: a paper mask covered in tiny printed words, cut from an old newspaper.

BRING TO THE BALL

- [ ] This booklet, folded shut
- [ ] A pen for your notes
- [ ] Your costume and mask

How this booklet works

Before the ball: read page 2 alone. It holds your story and your secret.

Round 1: the top half of page 3, when the Detective says so.

Round 2: the lower half of page 3, below the cut line.

Costume Parade: strike a pose and stay in character.

Round 3: page 4. Then everyone casts a ballot.

Print this booklet single-sided, or cut page 3 on its dashed line, so later rounds can't show through.

THE BALL

Every Halloween, Vesper Ravensworth opens the old candle works on the hill for the Candlewick Costume Ball. This year Vesper promised "an announcement that will change Candlewick Hollow" at nine o'clock. Before it could be made, Vesper sat down in the window chair of the Lantern Gallery and never woke up. Minutes earlier, guests saw the Lantern Ghost drift past the glass.

Never show this booklet to anyone. Bend the truth about your secret, never the evidence.

You are innocent.

You did not harm Vesper. You may still have something to hide.

> **If you are not in the game, nothing breaks.** You are an optional character: the case can be solved without you, so play for fun, share freely and enjoy your secret.

BACKGROUND

The folder holds the deed of gift: Candlewick Hall goes to the town as the Candlewick Lantern Museum. You helped draw it up.

YOUR SECRET

You privately advised the town council to refuse the gift because the roof repairs would cost a fortune. If Vesper had found out, you would have lost Vesper's trust.

WHAT YOU SAY ABOUT TONIGHT

From 8:30 to 8:45 you waited in Vesper's study with the door shut, as Vesper asked. At about 8:35 you heard soft footsteps pass in the gallery toward Vesper's chair and, a minute later, quick footsteps going back toward the Back Stairs.

YOUR GOALS

- Keep the deed of gift sealed until Round 2.
- Keep your advice to the council secret until Round 3.
- Find out who walked past the study door.

HOW TO USE YOUR BOOKLET

Read each round only when the Detective starts it. Say your Share lines in your own words, ask your two questions and try your task. You may dodge questions about your secret until your booklet tells you to share it, but never lie about what you saw, and never change what an evidence card says.

NOTES · WHO SAID WHAT

Round 1 · *The Grand Entrance*

ROUND 1

Read only when the Detective starts Round 1.

SHARE THIS WITH EVERYONE

You carry a sealed folder for Vesper's announcement and can't open it yet. From 8:30 you waited in the study with the door shut. At about 8:35 you heard soft footsteps go past toward Vesper's chair, and a minute later quick footsteps going back toward the Back Stairs.

ASK THESE QUESTIONS

? Ask **Hadley Cresswell:** "Were you the footsteps I heard in the gallery?"

? Ask **Darcy Wickliffe:** "Do you know what is in my folder?"

YOUR TASK

> Find out who was in the Lantern Gallery at 8:35.

CUT OR FOLD HERE · ROUND 2 BELOW · WAIT FOR THE DETECTIVE

Round 2 · *The Lantern Ghost*

ROUND 2

Read only when the Detective starts Round 2.

SHARE THIS WITH EVERYONE

Open the folder: it is the deed of gift. Candlewick Hall goes to the town as the Candlewick Lantern Museum, and everything inside will be valued and listed. Anyone hiding something in this house had until November 1.

ASK THESE QUESTIONS

? Ask **Marlo Quince:** "What will the museum do with the Dipping Room?"

? Ask **Auden Pryor:** "Is the archive part of the gift?"

YOUR TASK

> Read one line of the deed aloud to the room, in your most official voice.

NOTES · WHO SAID WHAT

Round 3 · *Unmasked*

ROUND 3

Read only when the Detective starts Round 3.

SHARE THIS WITH EVERYONE

Confess that you advised the council to refuse the gift because of the roof. You argued with paperwork, never with Vesper. Point out that the footsteps you heard went toward the Back Stairs, not toward the ballroom.

ASK THESE QUESTIONS

? Ask **Jory Greaves:** "Were you ever in the gallery tonight?"

? Ask **Teagan Bramwell:** "Who has a key to the Back Stairs door?"

YOUR TASK

> Help the Detective collect every ballot.

Notes

SUSPECTS AT THE BALL *(public · OPT. = may not be playing)*

10 Marlo Quince · Master Chandler of Candlewick Hall

11 Darcy Wickliffe · Vesper's younger cousin and heir

12 Perry Lanthorn · Lantern-maker who lights the Lantern Gallery

13 Briar Fallow · Costume maker of Candlewick Hollow

14 Jory Greaves · Pumpkin farmer and three-time carving champion

15 Hadley Cresswell · Editor of the Hollow Gazette

16 Auden Pryor (OPT.) · Town historian and keeper of the Lantern Ghost legend

17 Bexley Applegate (OPT.) · Owner of the Applegate cider press

18 Corin Thimble (OPT.) · Fiddler and leader of the ball's band

19 Larkin Hearthstone (OPT.) · Baker of the Candlewick pumpkin pies

20 Teagan Bramwell (OPT.) · Groundskeeper of Candlewick Hall

21 Ainsley Duskwood (OPT.) · Fortune-booth performer (stage act only)

22 Merritt Oxley (OPT.) · Town clerk carrying Vesper's papers

23 Wynn Pennywhistle (OPT.) · Photographer of the Costume Parade